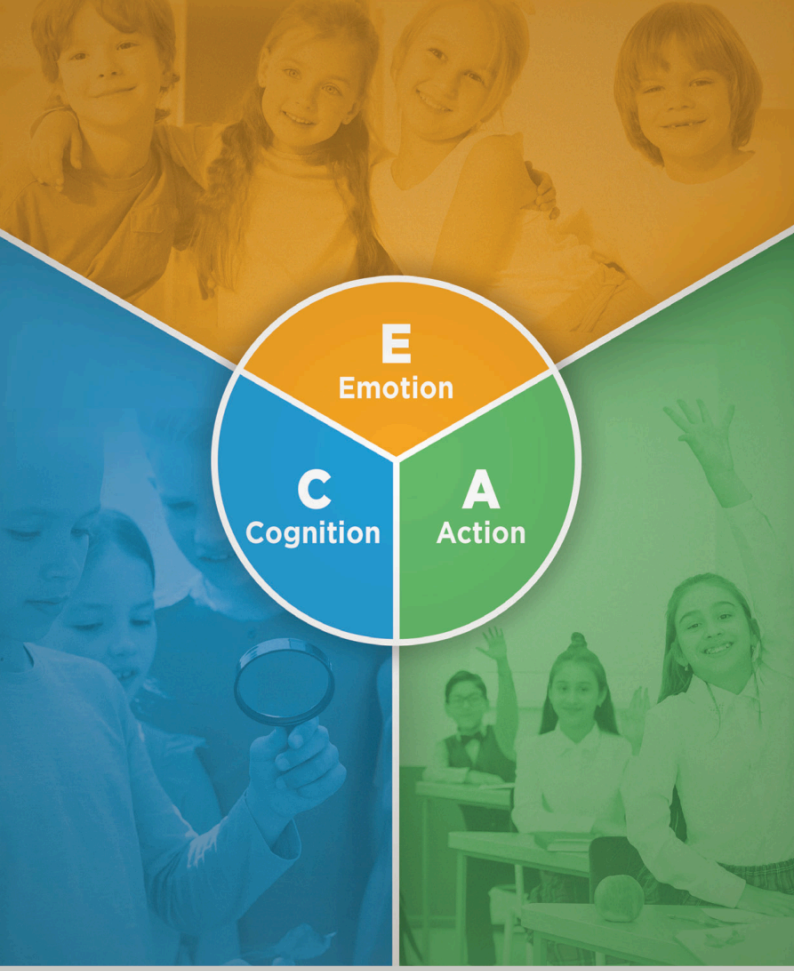


ECA Cards and User Guide

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The full name of the Meseliget Foundation's project is:
Developing a Skill Building Balanced Emotion, Cognition and Action

Publisher: Meseliget Foundation

Project's number: 2025-1-HU01-KA210-SCH-000360331

The project was carried out in collaboration with
the Polish partner organization Gedania1922

Call for proposals (start) date: 2025

AI Disclosure: Generative Artificial Intelligence tools (ChatGPT, Gemini, Perplexity, HeyGen, Napkin AI) were used in the production and translation of the content in this document. AI was utilized solely as a supportive tool: all outputs were validated based on our own sources, subjected to expert review, and modified as necessary. The project implementers maintain full responsibility for the accuracy and originality of the final content.

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Co-funded by the European Union

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What are the ECA Cards for?

The ECA Cards support person-centred pedagogical thinking and practice. They are not knowledge cards or worksheets to be completed in a prescribed order. Rather, they invite reflection, self-reflection, dialogue and action.

The cards are built around the three dimensions of **Emotion – Cognition – Action.** In the ECA approach, learning is not simply about understanding information. It also matters how we connect with what we are working on, what emotions and personal experiences we bring into the process, what we understand from it, and ultimately what we do with it in practice.

The three elements of ECA

E – Emotion: What do I feel? What touches me? What can I connect with? What causes resistance or uncertainty in me?

C – Cognition: What do I think about this? What do I understand from it? What connections do I discover? How does all this relate to my own teaching practice?

A – Action: What will I do with it? What will I try out? What will I change? What will my next concrete step be?

The three elements appear in different proportions on the individual cards. Some start more strongly from emotions or personal experience; others primarily encourage thinking and analysis; and still others lead more directly to action. There is therefore no need to classify the cards into E, C and A categories. The point is precisely that emotional connection should lead to thinking and, whenever possible, thinking should lead to action. This transition is also reflected in the cards: the ECA process moves from connection and awareness of emotional states through exploration to creation, practice and reflection.

Further resources

A more detailed presentation of the ECA approach, further methodological background materials, lesson plans and practical resources are available on the project website at ecaproject.eu.

ECA Cards HU 2026. Meseliget Foundation

In what situations can the cards be used?

For individual self-reflection

The cards can also be used individually when a teacher wants to pause for a moment and look at their own practice. A card can help identify emotions, habits, strengths or uncertainties, and then consider their pedagogical significance more consciously. It is important that self-reflection does not stop at recognition: it is worth ending with one small, concrete next step that the teacher can try out in their own practice. This use is particularly well suited to cards dealing with self-assessment and self-reflection.

In pairs and small groups

In pairs or small groups, the cards can primarily support professional dialogue. The same question may evoke different experiences, emotions and interpretations, so the aim is not for participants to arrive at a shared "correct answer". They can listen to one another's perspectives, ask questions, bring examples from their own practice, and then look together for solutions that could be tried out. In this way, working with the cards itself provides practice

in the acceptance, empathy and perspective-taking that are important in ECA.

In training sessions or staff workshops

In a training session, the cards can be used for tuning in, introducing a topic, group processing or closing a session. They make it easier to connect theoretical questions with participants' own teaching experiences. In a staff workshop, they can also help make shared strengths, different viewpoints and areas in which the community would like to change more visible. At the end of the discussion, it is worth choosing a shared action as well: something participants will try out over the following period and later evaluate together.

When working with real teaching situations and lesson planning

The cards can be used not only for reflection but also to shape teaching practice directly. A card chosen for an upcoming lesson, a difficult learning situation, a conflict or a question concerning a particular child can offer a new perspective. It can help us consider what the people involved are experiencing (E), what needs

to be better understood or interpreted differently (C), and what concrete change could be tried out (A). The card on preparing an ECA lesson itself encourages us, alongside our usual planning, to think more consciously about emotional connection, optional activities and different learning resources.

The cards can also be used in mentoring

The cards are particularly useful in mentor–mentee or coach–teacher situations. In such cases, the mentor does not necessarily choose the topic. The teacher can select the card that best connects with their current question.

The mentor's role is primarily to ask questions, listen and reflect back. They do not need to provide a ready-made solution. The aim is for the teacher to recognise for themselves what is happening within them and in the teaching situation, and then choose their own next step.

This use is especially close to the person-centred foundations of the cards. The card on the mentoring role also emphasises listening, recognising individual strengths, jointly developed goals, empathy and a non-judgemental attitude.

Some ideas for using the cards

1. My card for today – individual self-reflection

Choose or draw a card. Do not start answering the questions immediately. First notice your own reaction.

E: What does the card evoke in you? Does it feel familiar, interesting, uncomfortable, inspiring or perhaps irritating?

C: Read it again. Where do you encounter this topic? What are you already doing? What do you see differently?

A: Choose one small thing to try out over the next few days.

You can put the card aside and return to it a few days later: has anything happened since then?

2. Choose by feeling! – a training opener

Lay out several cards so that everyone can see them. Ask participants to choose one that speaks to them for some reason. They do not need to be able to explain why they chose that particular card.

E: What drew you to this card? What was your first reaction?

C: In pairs or small groups, discuss what pedagogical question it raises for you.

A: Everyone completes this sentence: "During today's session, I would like to understand / try out…"

This activity supports both personal arrival and the development of a shared focus for the work.

3. One card – two perspectives

Two participants work with the same card. First, they read it separately and do not discuss it for a few minutes.

E: What touched you? Which part did you react to most strongly?

C: Compare your thoughts. Did you notice the same things? What did you interpret differently?

A: Find a concrete teaching situation in which the idea on the card could be applied.

An important insight from this activity may be that the same pedagogical idea can mean different things to different people – and neither interpretation necessarily has to be "more correct" than the other.

4. Working through a real case

Someone in the group briefly presents a real teaching situation in which they feel uncertain or which causes them difficulty. Group members choose cards that connect with the situation in some way.

E: What happens within us as we listen to the story?

C: Let us look at the situation through the lens of the cards. What do we notice now that we did not see at first?

A: The group formulates several possible next steps. The person who brought the case responds to the suggestions.

Cards dealing with emotional intelligence or mediation are particularly suitable for this. The mediation card itself moves from recognising emotions and expressing needs towards a shared solution and a next step.

5. ECA glasses – lesson planning with a card

Choose a lesson that you will teach in the next few days. Draw a card and use it like a new pair of glasses: what do you see differently in the planned lesson through this lens?

E: How does this aspect affect the children's sense of safety, motivation or emotional engagement?

C: Does it change the questions they are asked or the choices available to them?

A: Change one concrete element of your lesson plan as a result of the card, and try it out.

You do not need to design a completely new lesson every time. One small change is enough.

6. Through the child's eyes – changing perspective

Choose a card and a particular child you teach. This time, do not answer the card's questions as a teacher; try to put yourself in the child's place.

E: How might this child feel in the situation?

C: What might they see differently from you? What might they understand from the situation? What might they need in order to connect?

A: What is one small thing you could change to make the situation better for them?

Cards about differences, autonomy, routines or needs can be particularly useful for this.

7. Three cards – E, C, A

Work in groups of 3–5. Choose three cards: one that, for you at this moment, primarily represents **Emotion,** one **Cognition,** and one **Action.** There is no correct solution. What matters is your reasoning. Discuss why each card was placed where it was. Where can you find the other two ECA elements in it? Then use the three cards to design a short learning situation:

- **E:** How do the children become emotionally engaged?
- **C:** What do they discover, understand or think through?
- **A:** What do they do, create, try out or change?

At the end, the groups present their mini ECA situations to one another.

8. My comfort zone

Look through the cards and choose two. The first should be one that makes you feel: **"I am already comfortable with this."** The second: **"This is difficult for me / I tend to avoid this."**

E: How did it feel to choose the second card? What causes the uncertainty or resistance?

C: What might be the reason? Lack of knowledge? Experience? Lack of time? Fear of losing control? Something else?

A: Do not try to solve the whole problem at once. Find one situation in which you would try something different.

The aim is not to look for shortcomings, but to identify your own next step in development.

9. Staff ECA map

Lay out the cards at a staff or professional workshop. First, everyone chooses one card in response to the question: **“What are we already strong at?”** Then choose another: **“What would it be good for us to develop together?”**

E: What experiences, successes or difficulties are connected with the chosen cards?

C: What pattern emerges? Do we see the same areas as strengths or as areas where something is missing?

A: Together, choose one shared, realistically achievable change to try out.

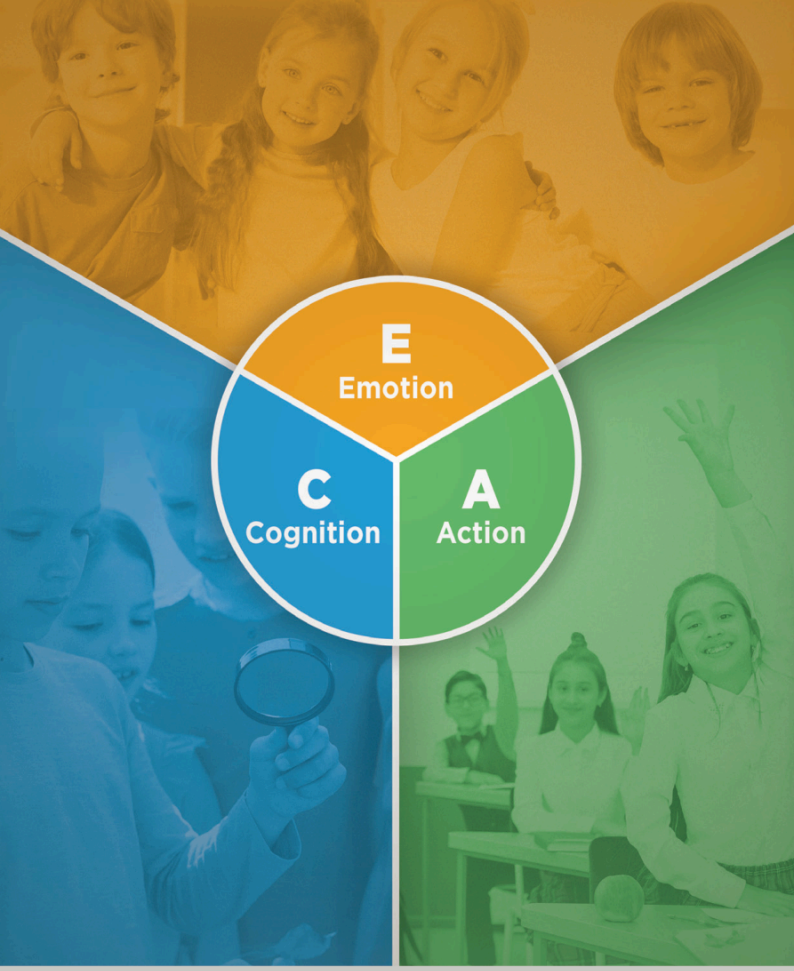
In this way, the cards can support not only individual self-reflection but also the development of a shared pedagogical culture.

10. Draw it again – from reflection to further action

Choose or draw a card and work with it in the usual way.

E: How does this affect you now?
C: What have you recognised or understood?
A: Choose one concrete thing to try out in practice. Then put the card aside. Take it out again a week later – now with the experience you have gained since then. What happened? What worked? What did not? How did you feel? What do you see differently now? What should your next step be? If you wish, you can take the same card with you into the following week.

In this way, ECA becomes not a straight line but a process: **connection → thinking → action → experience → reflection → further action.**



ECA Cards



1.

One goal of the ECA project is to prepare primary school teachers to provide students with the greatest possible learning autonomy in the safest possible learning environment. Another goal is to reinforce the attitude of person-centred education provide practical tools for person-centred, ECA-based education in primary school.

- *Find games, templates, lesson plans and checklists on the website: www.ecaproject.eu.*



2.

Traditional interactive lesson or ECA lesson

Consider-ation	Interactive tradi-tional class	ECA class
Motivation	Grade	Unique experience
Assess-ment	Grading based on performance	Process-oriented self-assessment
Differenti-ation	Difficult to solve	Naturally comes
Action	Limited	Multiple experien-tial, movements
Cognitive processing	Frontal, based on instructions	Self-contained, ex-ploring, individual
Emotional involvement	Low-medium	High
Role of the learner	Student recep-tive	Active experimen-tal
Focus	Transfer of knowl-edge	Experiences, com-plex development
Mode of operation	Instructions, problem solving	Unique products, complex

- *What do you agree and disagree with?*
- *Was there anything in the table that surprised you or made you think?*
- *What would you change if you could?*



3.

Emotion: connection, reading emotional states, emotional framing, a step towards cognition

Cognition: shared focus, discovery, organising together, brief consolidation

Action: transition into action, creation or practice, sharing, reflection

- *How would you rank the three components in order of importance?*
- *What do you think is missing from the list?*



4.

What does preparation mean for an ECA teacher?

1. **Defining the aim of the lesson** – no change.

2. **Selecting the learning content and linking it to previous learning** – no change

3. **Emotions:** Normally we include a short warm-up, but here this part is more detailed.

4. **Preparing the activities:** We usually don't prepare so many tasks to choose from.

5. **Preparing the resources:** Here we prepare for several different areas of intelligence.

6. **Preparing the materials and tools:** Diversity may mean more work.

- *How does it feel that preparation needs more energy.*
- *What can you get for the energy invested?*



5.

How can we create an appropriate, motivating and developmental learning environment for each student in a group?
We are different – accepting this fundamentally shapes the teacher's attitude.

- *What systems can you think of that support the idea that "we are different"?*
- *What would you include in an Individual Learning Contract?*
- *Think of your current class and write down the initials of three students who are very different from one another in terms of learning. In one word for each, name what makes them different learners.*
- *Decide which of them you will make one small personalised adjustment for next week (a different tool, different amount of work, a different type of task).*



6.

Learning is person-centred to the extent that self-assessment dominates the assessment process. This is what Carl Rogers states.

- *Think about how often you ask children: "How would you assess your work today?" Write down your honest estimate (never, sometimes, often).*
- *Write down two simple self-assessment questions that you will try at the end of a lesson next week.*
- *What is the relationship between the experience of success and self-assessment?*



7.

Self-reflection in the development of teacher competencies is not a separate technique, but a consequence of the approach that permeates the whole ECA perspective.

- *Choose one of the teacher roles (e.g. facilitator, mentor, team player) and mark on a scale of 1–10 how comfortable you currently feel in that role.*
- *In one sentence, describe a situation in which you will consciously practise this role next week (e.g. "during this group activity, I will only ask questions and will not provide solutions").*



8.



- *What elements make up your own practice? What are its intellectual and philosophical foundations, and what are its supporting pillars? What are its decorative elements? Which architectural style would you borrow to present ypur current teaching style?*
- *Formulate your teaching credo in five simple sentences.*



9.



- *Think through which of the above elements you provide in your classroom and which you do not.*

- *What would you change in the picture? What would you remove? What is missing? Adapt the picture to yourself.*



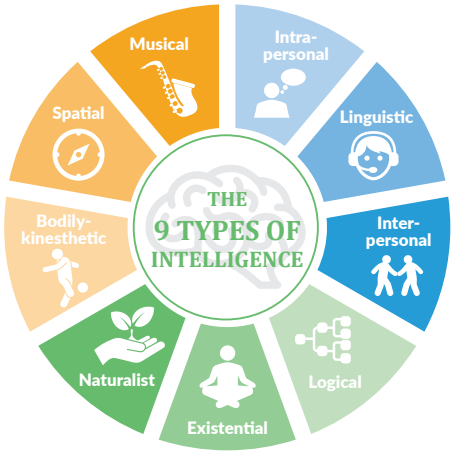
10.



- *Is student autonomy important to you? If yes, why? If not, why not?*
- *Think about how and to what extent you create situations for autonomous decision-making in your own classroom. Are you satisfied with this?*



11.

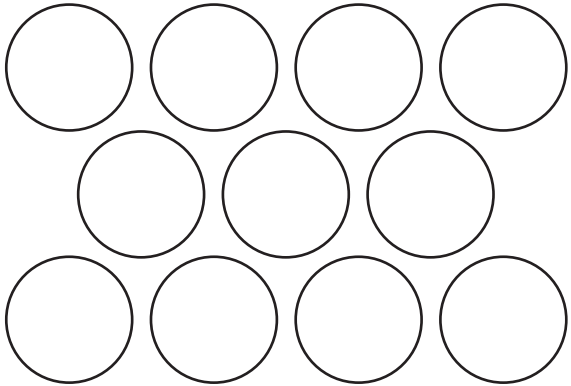


- *Think of five people in whom you recognise one of these intelligences. Describe what they are like.*
- *Which area are you good at? Which one is difficult for you?*
- *Design a lesson plan in which representatives of at least seven intelligences can find something enjoyable.*
- *Have you ever felt in your life that you were worth more than what teachers saw in you?*



12.

One useful tool for measuring creativity is the Torrance Test. It measures different areas of creativity, most commonly examining the quantity, variety, originality and elaboration of generated ideas.



- *Do a part of the test. Complete the circles so that they become as many different and interesting drawings as possible. Try to draw ideas that are varied and unusual. You may also give your drawings titles.*
- *What did this task mean to you?*



13.



Gary Chapman says: a Love language is the way a person expresses and experiences love. It is important to note that everyone speaks all of the languages, but each person has one (or two) primary loved one. It is a possibility to fill the "love tanks". Using them well, goodwill and care can reach children more easily. It is also be very helpful when giving assessment and feedback.

- *Which love language is the easiest for you to use to express your love, and which is the most difficult?*



14.

Person-centred attitude

Mark 0 = never/rarely / 1 = often / 2 = characteristic

Use:

- Observation
- Self-reflection
- Professional dialogue

Connection and safety

- I am present as an accepting, calm teacher. I can accept every child.
- Children feel safe enough to speak up.
- I encourage them to work and to make mistakes.
- I do not tell off them if they do not understand the task

Autonomy and participation

- I offer genuine choices.
- Children shape the process.

Communication and feedback

- I use descriptive, non-judgemental feedback.
- Questioning and reflecting back dominate.

Learning process

- The emphasis is on the process, not on the results.
- Conflicts are treated as learning situations.
- I have opportunities to teach them assertive communication.

Reflection

- There is closure and looking back every day.
- I use self-reflection on a daily basis.

Notes / direction for development:

- *What do you think it feels like to teach with this attitude?*



15.

Here are a few points that build a more personal relationship with students (mentoring role).

- Take time to truly listen to the child, noticing non-verbal signals as well.
- Consciously identify and reinforce each child's individual strengths.
- Respect rules of trust and confidentiality.
- Develop individual goals with each child; look for and observe changes together.
- Be consistent and authentic, and set an example.
- Give regular, constructive feedback.
- Active listening and empathy, supportive responses and a non-judgemental attitude are all important.
- Precise self-expression, honesty, flexibility and adaptability – practise them.

• *For at least five of these points, write one example of how it appears in your own life.*

• *Collect the obstacles and concerns you have in relation to these points.*

• *How much pressure do you feel when reading these points?*



16.

Emotional intelligence includes, among other things, self-awareness and emotional awareness.

- Recognising and naming one's own emotions in different situations.
- Being self-reflective.
- Recognising and managing one's own motivations in one's behaviour.
- Consciously integrating the connections between emotional and bodily reactions.

• *Imagine a child who is shouting, hitting things, clenching their fists, and using offensive language with a red face. You can see that the child is angry. List all the feelings that might be hidden behind this anger.*

• *What makes you feel angry?*



17.

Routines and subroutines help you stay on the person-centred path.

- Arrival and settling in:
- Opportunity to indicate one's state:
- Building in choice points: Genuine choices regularly appear during the day (task, tool, pace, role).
- Brief shared framing
- Action-based learning
- Flexible time management
- Observation instead of evaluation
- Treating conflicts as learning situations
- Closure and looking back
- Predictable, human presence

• *Please make a list of why, in your view, routines are important. Do not make the list from the teacher's or the class's perspective, but in terms of their impact on the individual.*
Why are routines good for a young child?

• *Choose one point and work out how you would apply it in your own lesson.*
How will you implement it?

• *What does it feel like to work with these tools?*



18.

This is a suggestion for self-reflection with younger primary school children. It is aimed at helping them understand that mistakes are a natural part of learning. It is worth using one or two of these each day.

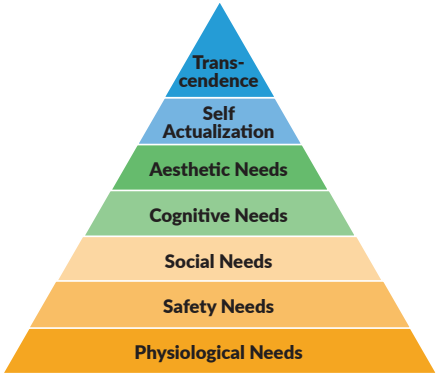
- What was I good at today?
- What was difficult at first, but then I managed it?
- What was very difficult, but I solved it?
- What do I need help with?
- What am I afraid of?
- What do I need to improve so that I can do a task even better next time?
- What did I discover that I can already do well?
- What am I better at today than I was yesterday?
- Did I make a mistake today? If yes, what will my next step be to avoid it next time?
- What am I proud of?

- *Do one of the exercises about this day of yours.*
- *Find something you can be proud of today.*
- *What does it feel like to be allowed to make mistakes?*



19.

Maslow's pyramid reminds us that higher-level learning goals can only be achieved when a person's basic physical, safety and relational needs are adequately met. As teachers, we always consider which level needs urgent attention at the moment – rest, safety, acceptance or challenge.



- *Create your own learning petrol station = what helps you be filled up: rest, safety, friends, challenge Is there another pump you would add?*

- *How would you feel in a place where none of these needs were taken into account, and in a place where they were?*



20.

Below you can read a few steps of mediation:

- I stop the situation: "Let's stop for a moment. What happened here is important."
- I listen to both sides separately: "Tell me what happened from your point of view."
- Naming feelings: "How did that feel for you? Were you embarrassed...?"
- Expressing a need or request: "What would you like to happen now? What are you asking from the other person?"
- Looking for a shared solution: "What solution could work for both of you?"
- Agreement and closure: "You have agreed that... What will you try next time?"

- *Imagine a conflict with one of your most difficult student. You want to use steps similar to these mediation steps. What do you do?*
  - *What would your first sentence be?*
  - *How would you describe what happened if you could only use I-messages and could only say how you feel? (You may not say "not again!", "never" or "always".)*
  - *How would you express empathy towards them?*
  - *How would you express your needs to them?*
  - *What solution would you suggest?*

- *How do you feel now? What thoughts come up?*
- *What will you do next time in a similar situation?*
- *How will you remind yourself of these steps?*